Appendix I

Meditation Scripts

Mindfulness of the Breath[1]

Find a quiet comfortable place to sit, so that you can remain in one position, back straight and gently supported, chin gently tucked toward the chest, shoulders dropped. Let your eyes close, fully or partially. Take three easy slow breaths.

Now bring your awareness to the position of your body and to the sensations inside your body. What do you notice? Perhaps you notice vibrations or pulsation, warmth or coolness, ease or tension. Fully feel your body. And just let it be as it is, whatever the sensations are.

Now see where you can discover your breath most strongly and most easily. Where do you feel your breathing? Do you feel it in your nostrils as the air goes in and out of your nose? Do you feel it in your chest as a rising and falling of your chest? Or do you feel your breathing in your abdomen as expansion and contraction? Where do you notice your breathing most easily and most strongly? If you can feel your breath in many areas, pick one. Allow your attention to stay on that location of your body, where you feel the breath most strongly. Allow yourself to feel the breath. Feel the breath and its sensations in your body.

As you breathe, you will notice that your mind wanders from time to time. This is what human minds do. Your mind wandering off is just part of the process. All you have to do is gently return your attention back to the breath when you notice

[1] Adapted from Christopher Germer's "Mindfulness of the Breath" (http://www.mindfulselfcompassion.org/meditations_instructions.php).

The Clinical Handbook of Biofeedback: A Step-by-Step Guide for Training and Practice with Mindfulness, First Edition. Inna Z. Khazan.
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that it has wandered off. It does not matter how many times your mind wanders, just bring it back with kindness, back to your breath, every time. Letting go of any thoughts or judgments that may come along the way. Gently return your attention back to your breath, feeling the sensations of your breath in your body. Just feel the breath.

Now bring your attention to the sensations of the inhalation. Notice what the sensations of the inhalation are in the part of your body where you feel your breath most strongly and most easily. Then notice the sensations of the exhalation. Notice what the sensations of the exhalation are in the part of your body where you feel your breath most strongly and most easily. Take a moment to wait until your body inhales again. Don't rush the inhalation, let yourself exhale fully and let the inhalation happen all on its own. There is no need to make the inhalation happen. Your body will do that for you, all on its own. Notice any thoughts or feelings that come to you during the transition from the exhalation into the inhalation or from the inhalation into the exhalation. Acknowledge those thoughts and feelings without engaging with them, letting them be, gently returning your attention to your breath. Allowing your breath to move from the inhalation into an exhalation, and from the exhalation into an inhalation. Let your experience between the breaths be just as it is, without attempting to change it. Just feel the breath. Feel the inhalation and the exhalation and allow whatever may arise during the pause after the exhalation to be just as it is, and then feel the breath again. Notice any urge to rush and let it go. Keep breathing in and out, gently, smoothly, paying attention to the sensations of the breath.

As you do this, your mind will naturally wander, and often, it will go off, perhaps distracted by a sound, or a thought, or a feeling, or a sensation. Sooner or later, you'll notice that your mind has wandered, and when you notice that, gently bring your attention back to the breath. . . . Feel the air. . . . When you mind wanders, notice that and gently go back to feeling your breath. Just feel the breath, and when you notice your mind has wandered, feel your breath again. One breath after the next. Inhalation flowing into an exhalation, and exhalation flowing into an inhalation.

Let your body breathe for you; it knows just what to do. Right now you are simply paying attention to the sensations of the breath in the body, in the place where you feel these sensations most easily. . . . Feel your breath again and again. . . . When your mind wanders, gently guide it back to your breath in the place where you feel it most easily and most strongly.

Now let go of the focus on the particular location where you feel your breath most strongly and allow yourself to feel your whole body move with each breath, expansion and contraction. Hardly perceptible movement of your whole body as you breathe. Let your body breathe for you, as it knows how to do so well. Feel your body move with each breath, back and forth.

Take as much time as you'd like to pay attention to the sensations of your breath and then whenever you are ready, open your eyes and once again become aware of your surroundings.

Raisin Meditation[2]

Hold a raisin in your hand, on your open palm, or between your two fingers. You are going to use every one of your senses to observe and examine the raisin. Allow this practice to be very slow, noticing and resisting the urge to rush.

Begin with carefully observing the raisin with your eyes. Notice its shape . . . color . . . patterns of light reflecting on its surface. . . . Notice some surfaces that are shiny, . . . others that are matte. Notice any thoughts or feelings that arise as you examine the raisin. . . . acknowledge them, . . . and let them go, gently returning your attention to the raisin.

Now, using your sense of touch, explore the raisin with two fingers. It may be helpful to close your eyes as you do this. Notice the texture of the raisin, . . . places where it feels soft . . . and places where it feels hard, . . . smooth . . . and rough, . . . its hills . . . and crevices, . . . the way they feel in your fingers. Again, notice any thoughts or feelings that arise as you explore the texture of the raisin, . . . acknowledge them, and gently return your focus to the raisin.

Lift the raisin to your ear, noticing the sensations of your arm lifting. Hold the raisin just outside your ear (don't put it in your ear) and roll it between two fingers, . . . pressing gently on the raisin, . . . noticing the soft sound the raisin makes under the pressure of your fingers.

If you notice any thoughts or feelings, . . . memories or questions evoked by the raisin, . . . thoughts about the rest of your day, . . . moments of doubt as to the purpose of what you are doing, . . . or if your mind just wanders off somewhere, . . . notice that and gently bring your attention back to the raisin.

Now slowly bring the raisin to your nose and breathe in its scent. Take a few slow, . . . smooth breaths in. What do you notice? . . . What is your reaction to the aroma you breathe in? If you notice thoughts, feelings, or judgments, acknowledge them, and return your attention to the smell of the raisin.

Finally, place the raisin in your mouth, without biting into it. Just let it stay on your tongue for a few moments. . . . Notice the initial taste sensation, . . . explore the texture of the raisin with your tongue. How does the texture feel to you now? . . . Is it similar or in any way different from the texture you noticed with your fingers? . . . Now, take one slow bite into the raisin, just one. Notice the taste of that one bite, the sensations of your teeth biting into the raisin. Notice any urge to continue biting into the raisin, . . . any urge to rush. Now continue exploring the raisin with your tongue . . . how has it changed since you've bitten into it? Continue to slowly chew the raisin, . . . very . . . very slowly, . . . noticing all the sensations as you are chewing –. . . taste, . . . texture, . . . shape, . . . the movement of your jaw, . . . any thoughts or feelings that arise. Swallow the raisin once there is nothing left to chew. . . . Stay with the sensations in your mouth – what is different now? Stay with

[2] Adapted from Ronald Siegel's *The Mindfulness Solution: Everyday Practices for Everyday Problems* (2009).

those sensations for as long as you wish, and whenever you are ready, return your awareness to everything else around you.

Mindfulness of Sound

Find a reasonably quiet place (no TV or people talking), sit in a comfortable position, settle into your seat. Let your eyes close, either fully or partially. Begin with several calm breaths, paying attention to each breath as it comes in and goes out. . . .

Now, bring your awareness to the sounds all around you. . . . Just listen. . . . What do you hear? What do you feel as you listen? . . . Just sit and let your ears pick up sounds near and far, all around, in all directions. Let yourself sit and receive the sound vibrations. You don't need to label the sounds, you don't need to interpret the sounds, you don't need to seek out the sounds, you don't even need to like the sounds. Just sit in the middle of the sound environment, let the sound come to you, let it present itself to you . . . just listen and take in every sound. . . .

You might find your mind latching on to a sound and going down the path of interpretation, thinking about the sound or its meaning. You might notice thoughts or feelings arising in response to the sound. You might find yourself judging the sound or your reaction to it. All of that is OK. If you notice your mind wandering off from the vibrations of the sound, notice where it's been, and then gently bring your attention back to the sound, just as it is.

Listen . . . You don't need to pay special attention to any particular sound, just let all sounds come and go as they please. You don't need to name the sounds, you don't need to figure out what they mean, you don't need to like the sounds, just let the sounds be sounds, just let yourself hear them. Just listen. . . .

Mindfulness of Thoughts, Feelings, and Physiological Sensations[3]

Get into a comfortable position in your chair, sit upright, feet flat on the floor, arms and legs uncrossed, hands resting on your lap, palms up or down, as is most comfortable for you. Allow your eyes to close, either fully or partially.

Now bring your awareness to the physical sensations in your body, beginning with the sensations of touch or pressure where your body makes contact with the chair or the floor – your back against the back of the chair, your arms on the armrests, and your feet on the floor.

[3] Adapted from *The Mindfulness and Acceptance Workbook for Anxiety: A Guide to Breaking Free from Anxiety, Phobias, and Worry Using Acceptance and Commitment Therapy* by Georg Eifert and John Forsyth (2008).

Take a few moments to get in touch with the movement of your breath in your chest and abdomen. Feel the rhythm of your breath in your body, like ocean waves coming in and out. Focus on each inhalation and exhalation, breathing in and out. Notice the changing patterns of sensation in your chest and abdomen as you breathe in and out.

There is no need to control your breathing in any way; simply let your body breathe for you. As best you can, bring an attitude of gentle acceptance and allowing to your breath. There is nothing to be fixed, no particular goal, no particular state to be achieved. Simply allow your experience to be your experience, without needing it to be anything other than what it is.

Sooner or later your mind will wander away from your breath to other thoughts, ideas, worries, concerns, images, daydreams, or it may just drift along. This is what human minds do. When you notice your mind has wandered off, is the time when you have once again become aware of your experience. You may want to acknowledge where your mind has been – "there is thinking" or "there is feeling." Then gently guide your attention back to the sensation of the breath coming in and going out. As best you can, bring kindness and compassion to your awareness, perhaps seeing the repeated wanderings of your mind as opportunities to bring patience and gentle curiosity to your experience.

When you become aware of any tension, discomfort, or other physical sensations in a particular part of the body, notice them, acknowledge their presence, and see if you can make space for them. Do not try to hold on to them or make them go away, see if you can make some room for the discomfort or tension, just allowing them to be there. Watch the sensations change from moment to moment. Sometimes they grow stronger, sometimes they grow weaker, and sometimes they stay the same. Notice the changing patterns of sensation and allow them to be, just as they are. Breathe calmly into and out from the sensations of discomfort, gently guiding your breath toward that region of the body. Remember the intention is not to make you feel better, but to get better at feeling.

If you ever notice that you are unable to focus on your breathing, because of intense physical sensation in any part of your body or because of an intense emotion, let go of the focus on the breath and shift your attention to the place of physical discomfort in your body or the place in your body where you feel the emotion most strongly. Gently direct your attention to the discomfort and stay with it no matter how bad it seems. Take a look at it; what does it really feel like? Again, see if you can make room for the discomfort, allow it to be there and be willing to stay with it.

Along with physical sensations in your body, you may also notice thoughts about the sensations and thoughts about the thoughts. You may notice your mind judging your experience, or coming up with evaluations such as dangerous or unpleasant. You may notice your mind coming up with predictions of what will happen next, or questions about how things will turn out. When you notice evaluations, or judgments, predictions, or questions, acknowledge them, and return to the present experience as it is, not as your mind says it is, noticing thoughts as thoughts, physical

sensations as physical sensation, feelings as feelings, nothing more, nothing less. If you notice questions, gently answer them with "I don't know" and return to your present experience, just as it is.

To help you bring some distance between yourself and your thoughts and feelings, you can label the thoughts and feeling as you notice them. For example, if you notice yourself worrying, silently say to yourself "worry, there is worry." Observe the worry without engaging with it, allowing it to stay. If you find yourself judging, notice that and label "judging, there is judging." Observe the judgment with kindness and compassion. You can do the same with other thoughts and feelings, just naming them: there is planning, or remembering, or wishing, or dreading, or whatever your experience may be. Label your thoughts or emotions, and move on. Notice how thoughts and feelings come and go in your mind and body. You are not what those thoughts and feelings say, not matter how intense or persistent they may be.

As this time for formal practice comes to an end, gradually widen your attention to take in the sounds around you. Now slowly open your eyes, notice your surroundings, and allow the awareness of the present moment to stay with you throughout the day.

Body Awareness[4]

Lie down flat on your back or sit up comfortably. Leave arms and legs uncrossed, hands resting on your lap or at your sides, as is most comfortable for you. Allow your eyes to close.

Begin with bringing attention to the feet, noticing the physical sensations in your feet. What are you noticing? Perhaps the sensations of warmth or coolness, dryness or moisture. Notice the sensations, whatever they are, and let them be. Bring gentle curiosity to the experience of your feet, explore every part of your right foot – the sides, the arch, the ball of the foot, the top of the foot, the bottom of the foot, and each toe, one at a time. Notice the sensations and make space for them, let them stay just the way they are. Now the left foot – the sides, the arch, the ball of the foot, the top of the foot, the bottom of the foot, and each toe, one at a time. Notice the sensations, and allow them to stay.

Now move your attention up to the ankles, noticing all the sensations in the right ankle and the left ankle. Whatever sensations you notice, explore them and allow them to be there just as they are.

Moving the attention up to your calves, the right calf and the left calf, observing the sensations, and letting them be, just as they are. There is no need to change anything about your experience right now, simply allow yourself to attend to your experience just as it is.

[4] Adapted from "Compassionate Body Scan" by Christopher Germer (http://www.mindfulself compassion.org/meditations_instructions.php).

Your mind will wander from time to time. That is what human minds do. Notice the thoughts that come into your mind, and then gently bring your attention back to your body. Allow yourself not to struggle with the wanderings of your mind. Simply bring your mind back each time you become aware of its wandering. If any judgments enter your mind, acknowledge them and let them go. Bring kindness and compassion to the wanderings of your mind and to all of your experience.

Now, bring your attention to your knees and make space for whatever sensations you notice in your knees – the right knee and the left knee. If you notice any discomfort or more intense sensations, attend to them with kindness and compassion – you may want to place your hand on the knee and gently rub it, as a way of expressing compassion.

Now move your attention up to your thighs, noticing all the sensations in the thighs, the right thigh and the left thigh. Let the sensations be just as they are, exploring them in your mind, making space for all the sensations, whatever they might be.

Bringing your attention now to your backside, paying attention to the sensations of touch or pressure where your backside comes in contact with the chair or floor. Exploring the sensations with kindness and curiosity. Again, remember there is no need to change anything, no need to fix anything about your experience. Just allow yourself to attend to the experience as it is.

Now guide your attention to your abdomen, exploring the sensations in your abdomen and letting them be. Noticing the sensations of your breath as your abdomen gently moves up and down, with each inhalation and exhalation. If you notice any discomfort or more intense sensations, attend to them with kindness and compassion – you may want to place your hand on your abdomen, allowing the warmth of your hand to provide comfort.

If you notice your mind wandering, acknowledge where the mind has been and then gently escort it back to the sensations in your body, letting go of any thoughts or judgments that come along the way.

Now bring your attention to your lower back, noticing all the sensations in the lower back, allowing them to be, bringing gentle curiosity to the sensations in your lower back. If you notice any discomfort, attend to it with kindness and compassion. Stay with the sensations, allowing them to be just as they are, guiding your breath toward the area of discomfort.

Gently bring your attention to your chest now. Notice the sensations of your heartbeat, allowing them to be just as they are. Observing all the sensations in your chest with curiosity, making space for these sensations, letting them be. There is no need to change anything right now, nothing that needs to be fixed. Make room for all the sensations in your chest, attend to them with kindness.

Now bringing your attention to your upper back, observing and exploring all the sensations in your upper back. Noticing the sensations of touch or pressure where your back comes in contact with the chair or floor. Making space for all the sensations. If you notice any discomfort, attend to it with kindness and compassion. Stay with the sensations, allowing them to be just as they are, guiding your breath toward the area of discomfort.

Moving your attention now to your arms and hands – the right arm: the upper arm, the lower arm, the hand and each finger – the thumb, the index finger, the middle finger, the ring finger and the little finger. Attend to the sensations in the right arm, allowing them to stay. Now the left arm: the upper arm, the lower arm, the hand and each finger – the thumb, the index finger, the middle finger, the ring finger, and the little finger. Exploring sensations in your left arm and hand with curiosity and kindness.

When you notice your mind wandering, acknowledge where the mind has been, and gently bring it back to the sensations in your body. Notice and let go of any judgments and thoughts that come along the way.

Now bringing your attention to the shoulders – the left shoulder, and the right shoulder. Observing the sensations, acknowledging them and letting them be. If you notice any discomfort, make space for it and attend to it with kindness and compassion. You may want to gently rub your shoulders in the area of discomfort, as a way of expressing compassion. Stay with the sensations of discomfort, exploring them, noticing what they are really like, and allowing them to be.

Gently moving your attention to the neck, bringing gentle curiosity to your experience of the sensations in the neck, allowing them to be just as they are. If you notice any discomfort, or more intense sensations, attend to them with curiously and compassion. Make space for the sensations and allow them to stay. You might place your hand over the area of discomfort, allowing the warmth of your hand to bring soothing and comfort.

Now move your attention to the head, starting with the chin, mouth, and lips. Noticing all the sensations in your chin, mouth, and lips and allowing them to stay. Then moving on to the cheeks, the nose, the eyes, making room for all the sensations in the cheeks, the nose, and the eyes, exploring them with gently curiosity. Moving to the ears, the forehead, and the top of the head. Allowing all the sensations in the ears, the forehead, and the top of the head to stay, attending to them with kindness and compassion.

Finally, give yourself a moment to reflect on the hard work your body does every day. Bring some gratitude and appreciation to each part of the body, to each organ, each muscle for the work they do every single day. Bring some kindness to your body, bring some compassion, and appreciation.

Thoughts on Leaves Meditation

Find a comfortable spot for you to sit or lie down, gently supported. Allow your breathing to become smooth and regular. Bring your attention into the present moment, and to the sensations of your breath, the sensations of your body, particularly where it is making contact with the chair or the floor. Take a few easy, comfortable breaths. And as you breathe, imagine yourself walking through the forest. Green grass under your feet, tall trees around you, blue sky overhead. You know the way around the forest, you are safe and protected. The sun is just right, not too warm.

You feel the gentle breeze on your face. Listen to the birds overhead. Breathe in the fragrance in the air, so crisp and refreshing. Feel every step that you take. As you walk, you come to a meadow – soft green grass, wildflowers, trees all around it. Notice a shallow, fast stream of water at the edge of the meadow, underneath the trees. Come up to it and find a place to sit comfortably. Take a moment to pay attention to the water, as it runs over the rocks on the bottom of the shallow stream. Listen to the babbling sound of the water. Notice how clean and clear the water is; you can see every piece of sand, every pebble on the bottom. You might even touch the water with your hand, noticing how cool and refreshing it is.

And notice how from time to time a leaf falls from the tree, gently floats toward the stream, lands in the water, and is carried away by the current. And another leaf falls from the tree, floats toward the water, and is carried away. Watch how the leaf slowly descends, twirling slightly toward the water, landing on its surface and floating away, out of sight.

Now pay attention to the thoughts going through your mind right now. Whatever those thoughts are, notice them, pick one, attend to it kindly for a moment, long enough to label the thought as planning, or wishing, or worrying, or predicting, or whatever the thought might be. Now imagine gently taking it out of your mind and placing it on one of those falling leaves, watching it twirl toward the water, land on its surface and float away, out of sight. Notice another thought, attend to it for a moment with curiosity, label it, place it on a falling leaf, watch it twirl toward the water and float away, out of sight. There is no need to engage with those thoughts, no need to change them in any way, no need to hold on to them, no need to make them go away. Simply notice a thought, label it, place it on a leaf, and watch it float away.

When you notice your mind engaging with a thought and following it somewhere, acknowledge that, and wherever you find your mind going, gently allow it to return to watching your thoughts, and the leaves, and the stream. Notice a thought, label it, place it on a leaf, and watch it float away, out of sight. You will notice that some thoughts come back, again and again. That is what our thoughts do, they come and go, they come and go. No matter whether you've experienced this thought before a moment ago or if you haven't seen it in a while, notice it, attend to it for a brief moment, with kindness, label it, place it on a leaf, and watch it land on the water and float away. There is no need to engage or argue with the thoughts, no need to change the thoughts, no need to hold on to them or make them go away. Simply attend to the thoughts, coming and going, coming and going. Notice a thought, label it, place it on a leaf and watch it float away, out of sight.

If you notice yourself judging yourself for having some of those thoughts, or judging the thoughts themselves, notice that, label the judging thought as judgment, place it on a leaf, watch it twirl toward the stream and float away. Watch thoughts come and go, as they always do. Whatever the thought is, notice it, attend to it with kindness, place it on a leaf and watch it float away. Now take as much time as you'd like to attend to your thoughts, watching them come and go. Whenever you are ready, open your eyes, and return to the room.

Mindfulness of Temperature Sensations in the Body

Lie down on your back, recline, or sit up comfortably. Leave your arms and legs uncrossed, hands resting on your lap or at your sides, as is most comfortable for you. Allow your eyes to close.

Begin with bringing attention to the feet, noticing the temperature sensations in your feet. What are you noticing? Perhaps the sensations of warmth or coolness, dryness or moisture. Notice the sensations, whatever they are, and let them be. Bring gentle curiosity to the experience of your feet, explore every part of right foot. Do some parts of the foot feel warmer or cooler than the others? Notice the temperature sensations of the sides, the arch, the ball of the foot, the top of the foot, the bottom of the foot, and each toe, one at a time. Notice the sensations and make space for them; let them stay just the way they are. Now the left foot – observe the temperature sensations of the sides, the arch, the ball of the foot, the top of the foot, the bottom of the foot, and each toe, one at a time. Notice the sensations, and allow them to stay.

Now move your attention up to the ankles, noticing the sensations of warmth or coolness in the right ankle and the left ankle. Whether you notice warmth or coolness, or any other sensations, explore them and allow them to be there just as they are.

Moving the attention up to your calves, the right calf and the left calf, observing the sensations of warmth and coolness, and letting them be, just as they are. There is no need to change anything about your experience right now, no need to warm up or cool off, simply allow yourself to attend to your experience just as it is.

Your mind will wander from time to time. That is what human minds do. Notice the thoughts that come into your mind, and then gently bring your attention back to your body. Allow yourself not to struggle with the wanderings of your mind. Simply bring your mind back each time you become aware of its wandering. If any judgments enter your mind, acknowledge them and let them go. Bring kindness and compassion to the wanderings of your mind and to all of your experience.

Now, bring your attention to your knees and make space for the temperature sensations you notice in your knees – the right knee and the left knee. Now moving your attention up to your thighs and backside, noticing the sensations of warmth or coolness in the thighs, the right thigh and the left thigh, and in the backside. Let the sensations be just as they are, exploring them, making space for the sensations of temperature, whatever they might be, warm or cool, hot or cold. Explore the sensations with kindness and curiosity. Again, remember there is no need to change anything, no need to fix anything about your experience. Just allow yourself to attend to the experience as it is.

Now guide your attention to your abdomen, exploring the temperature sensations in your abdomen and letting them be. Noticing the sensations of your breath as your abdomen gently moves up and down, with each inhalation and exhalation. Do the temperature sensations in your abdomen change with each inhalation and exhalation or do they stay the same? If you notice your mind wandering,

acknowledge where the mind has been and then gently escort it back to the sensations in your body, letting go of any thoughts or judgments that come along the way.

Now bring your attention to your lower back, noticing the sensations of warmth or coolness in the lower back, allowing them to be, bringing gentle curiosity to the sensations in your lower back. Gently bring your attention to your chest now. What temperature sensations do you notice there? Do the sensations change with each beat of your heart or do they stay the same? Observing the sensations of warmth of coolness in your chest with curiosity, and making space for the sensations, letting them be. There is no need to change anything right now, nothing that needs to be fixed.

Now bring your attention to your upper back, observing and exploring the temperature sensations in your upper back. Noticing any change in those sensations where your back comes in contact with the chair. Making space for all the sensations.

Move your attention now to your arms, attending to the sensations of temperature in your arms, the right arm: the upper arm and the lower arm. The left arm: the upper arm and the lower arm. Notice any change in temperature sensations where your arms are no longer covered by clothing.

Gently guide your attention now to your hands, the right hand, and each finger – the thumb, the index finger, the middle finger, the ring finger, and the little finger. Notice all the temperature sensations. Some fingers may feel warmer, while other fingers may feel cooler. Attend to the temperature sensations in the right hand and fingers, and allow them to stay. There is nothing that needs to change right now, nothing to be fixed. Bring kindness and compassion to the temperature sensations in your hands and fingers, whatever the sensations are. Now the left hand and each finger – the thumb, the index finger, the middle finger, the ring finger, and the little finger. Exploring the temperature sensations in your left hand and fingers with curiosity and kindness. Allowing the sensations of coolness or warmth to stay just as they are. Nothing needs to change, nothing to be fixed.

When you notice your mind wandering, acknowledge where the mind has been, and gently bring it back to the temperature sensations in your body. Notice and let go of any judgments and thoughts that come along the way.

Now bringing your attention to the shoulders – the left shoulder, and the right shoulder. Observing the sensations of warmth and coolness, acknowledging them and letting them be. Gently moving your attention to the neck, bringing gentle curiosity to your experience of the temperature sensations in the neck, allowing them to be just as they are. Make space for the sensations and allow them to stay.

Now move your attention to the head, starting with the chin, mouth, and lips. Noticing all the temperature sensations in your chin, mouth, and lips and allowing them to stay. Then moving on to the cheeks, the nose, the eyes, making room for the sensations of warmth or coolness in the cheeks, the nose, and the eyes, exploring them with gentle curiosity. Moving to the ears, the forehead, and the top of the

head. Allowing the sensations of warmth or coolness in the ears, the forehead, and the top of the head to stay, attending to them with kindness and compassion.

Now bring one or both of your hands to your heart, placing them gently over your heart. Attend to the sensations of warmth and coolness as you explore the feeling in your hands and chest. Notice the changing pattern of sensations in your hands and in each finger. Attend to those sensations with kindness and curiosity and allow them to stay. Observe the changes in the sensations of warmth and coolness, whatever they might be, and let them stay.

Difficult Emotion Practice[5]

Find a comfortable position, sitting up or lying down. Allow your eyes to close, either fully or partially. Bring your awareness to your breath for a few moments, noticing the sensations of your breath as it comes in and as it goes out. Notice the sensations of air entering your nostrils, your chest and belly gently rising with each inhalation, and falling with each exhalation, as the air flows back out of the nostrils. Notice the sensations in your body, especially the sensations of touch or pressure where your body comes in contact with the chair (or the bed, couch, or floor) – your back against the back of the chair, your arms on the armrests, your feet on the floor. Notice the external sensations of the position of your body in the chair or on the floor, and the internal sensations within your body – your breath, your heartbeat, the pulsation and vibration of your body.

Now let yourself remember a mildly difficult situation. Recall what happened, what you were thinking and especially what you were feeling. Now expand your awareness to your body as a whole. While you recall the emotion, notice where you feel the emotion in your body. In your mind's eye, sweep your body from head to toe, stopping where you can sense a little tension or discomfort.

Now choose a single location in your body where the feeling expresses itself most strongly, perhaps as a point of muscle tension or an achy feeling. In your mind, incline gently toward that spot. Continue to breathe naturally, allowing the sensation to be there, just as it is. If you wish, place your hand over your heart as you continue to breathe. Allow the gentle, rhythmic motion of the breath to soothe your body.

If you feel overwhelmed by an emotion, bring your attention to your breath and stay with it until you feel better and then return to the emotion.

Now allow yourself to soften into the location in your body where you feel the emotion most strongly. Let the muscles be softer without a requirement that they become soft or that they relax. Just let the muscles soften like they do when you

[5] Adapted from Christopher Germer's "Mindfulness of Emotion in the Body" and "Soften, Soothe, and Allow" (http://www.mindfulselfcompassion.org/meditations_instructions.php).

apply heat to sore muscles. You can say silently to yourself, "soft . . . soft . . . soft . . ." as you allow your muscles to soften around the area of discomfort. Remember that you are not trying to make the sensation go away, you are simply allowing your body to soften while letting the sensations of discomfort stay.

Now soothe yourself for struggling in this way. If it feels comfortable, place your hand over your heart and feel your body breathe. Or you might direct some kindness to the part of your body where you feel the difficult emotion by placing your hand over that place. Feel the warmth of your hand, soothing and bringing comfort. You might send your breath to the part of the body where you feel the difficult emotion, soothing and comforting. Silently say to yourself, "soothe . . . soothe . . . soothe."

Finally, allow the discomfort to be there. Abandon the wish for the feeling to disappear. Let the discomfort come and go, make space for it, and allow it to be just as it is. Repeat silently to yourself, "allow . . . allow . . . allow."

Now put it all together, letting your body soften, soothing yourself for struggling, and allowing the difficult feelings to stay, saying silently to yourself, "Soften, soothe, and allow." "Soften, soothe, and allow." You can use these three words like a mantra, rolling them around in your mind.

Stay with your feelings and with the mantra for as long as you wish, and whenever you are ready, slowly open your eyes and return to the rest of your experience.

Loving-Kindness Meditation (Mettā)[6]

Find a quiet comfortable place to sit, with your back gently supported, in a relaxed posture. Let your eyes close, fully or partially. Take a few easy, slow breaths, bring your awareness to your body and into the present moment.

Bring to mind a person or another living being who naturally makes you smile. This could be a child, a grandparent, a pet – whoever naturally brings happiness to your heart and a smile to your face. If you can't think of a living being, think back to a memory of a place where you felt happy and at ease. Allow the feelings of what it is like to be in the company of that being to come into the present moment. Allow yourself to enjoy their company.

Now, recognize how vulnerable this loved one is. Just like you, vulnerable to sickness, aging, bad things happenings, death. And just like you and every other living being, your loved one wishes to be happy and healthy and free from suffering. Keeping the warm kind loving feelings you have for your loved one close to your heart, repeat to yourself, silently or out loud, slowly, softly, and gently, feeling the importance of your words:

[6] Adapted from Christopher Germer's "Loving-Kindness Meditation" (http://www.mindfulself compassion.org/meditations_instructions.php).

May you be safe and free from harm
May you be healthy and free from suffering
May you have contentment and peace of mind
May you care for yourself with ease and well-being

When you notice that your mind has wandered, return to the words and the image of the loved one you have in mind. Return to the feelings of warmth, kindness, love, and compassion.

Now add yourself to your circle of warmth and good will. If it feels comfortable, place your hand over your heart, feel the warmth and comfort of your hand, and say, slowly and gently:

May you and I be safe and free from harm
May you and I be healthy and free from suffering
May you and I have contentment and peace of mind
May you and I care for ourselves with ease and well-being

Visualize your whole body in your mind's eye, notice any tension, discomfort, stress, or uneasiness that may be lingering within you, and offer warmth, comfort, and kindness to yourself.

May I be safe and free from harm
May I be healthy and free from suffering
May I have contentment and peace of mind
May I care for myself with ease and well-being

Now bring your attention to your breath, take a few easy comfortable breaths, and just rest quietly in your own body, savoring the good will and compassion that flow naturally from your own heart. Know that you can return to the phrases and the feelings that come with them anytime you wish. Whenever you are ready, gently open your eyes.

There are many variations of the mettā phrases. If you or your clients wish for simpler phrases, here's a good alternative:

May you be safe
May you be peaceful
May you be healthy
May you live with ease

When your client practices this meditation in the moment of need, she could wish for whatever it is she needs at that moment: "May I have comfort," "May I be at ease," "May I be kinder to myself," "May I have peace", and "May I be free from suffering."

Please remember that the goal of the mettā practice is not to bring on specific feelings, or to change the present moment. The goal is to bring some kindness,

warmth, good will, and compassion into the present moment, along with whatever else exists in that moment.

You practice mettā not in order to feel better, but because you feel bad.

References

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